

with speculations regarding the creation process that we have come across in Jewish spirituality since the *Sefer Yetzirah*. Programmatically he states: “The creation of the world was done by conversions and rotations of the letters.”⁵⁸ In his search for the *prisca theologia*, Knorr “defines a new code for the kabbalistic deciphering of the biblical text, which offers the possibility to interpret the sefirotic world as a parallel structure of our immanent structure of being.”⁵⁹

In the seventeenth century, Knorr von Rosenroth and others linked such a mystical hermeneutics to another mirror of perfect knowledge—the encyclopaedia. I will deal with this topic in chapter 9. Regarding the ‘secrets of texts,’ however, a brief look into the universalizing tendencies of early modern philology is important at this point.

*Humanistic Philology:
Universal Languages and the Quest for the Ursprache*

The movement that today is called ‘humanism’ was a highly polemical project. Between the twelfth and the fifteenth centuries a critical response to scholasticism was formed that claimed the authority of philological scrutiny.⁶⁰ With their battle cry “*ad fontes*” (“back to the sources”) the humanists applied the hermeneutical and text-critical interpretational tools for pagan literature to the biblical texts, thus contextualizing and historicizing the biblical revelation to a degree that had been impossible in earlier periods. In addition to the theological challenge related to this maneuver of contextualizing and relativizing, the humanists polemicized against the authority of theologians and clerics, ultimately leading to the Reformation endeavor of making the biblical text available to everyone. To be sure, while some saw in Luther’s translation of the Bible a democratization of theology, others regarded it as a sacrilege and profanization. Be this as it may, one result was the emergence of classical philology as a distinct academic discipline, and of philological experts who critically reflected on basic

⁵⁸ “De Creatione mundi factâ per conversiones et rotationes literarum [...]” (Knorr von Rosenroth, *Kabbala Denudata*, vol. I, 208).

⁵⁹ Morlok, “Text als Textur,” 179.

⁶⁰ See Rummel, *Humanist-Scholastic Debate*.

tenets of theology—both Christian and non-Christian—in the Republic of Letters.⁶¹

The humanist movement was polemical in another regard as well. The urge to go *ad fontes* was also directed against the Islamic interpretation of Aristotelianism, which had been taken over by Christian scholastics.⁶² In an anti-Islamic polemic humanists argued that the Arabic tradition had distorted the original Greek philosophy and that Christians would have to come to their own conclusions regarding the heritage of ancient paganism. Thus, a two-fold religious polemic fostered the emergence of what was to become known as philology.

At first glance, academic philology of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries may look like a sober revaluation of religious texts. However, when we take a closer look at the field of philology, we encounter many actors who are well known from the history of esoteric discourses. This is because many humanist philologists were not simply interested in the objective description of the development of human languages or the exact contextualization and translation of ancient texts; many humanists applied the instruments of philological scrutiny to their overall search for the ultimate language, or *Ursprache*. The quest for the “Adamic language” that was spoken in Paradise and that therefore represented the closest affinity to the divine or sacred language is particularly relevant for experts of the Hebrew language. Within the humanist movement, the Christian Hebraists played a crucial role, both for esoteric interpretations of the cosmos and for the emergence of modern societies.

From antiquity to the present Jewish-Christian encounters have played a key role in defining attitudes toward personal, national, and religious identity in Western culture. These definitions, in turn, involved debates about history, religion, morality, and truth in general. The work of the Christian Hebraists [...] impinged on all these highly sensitive areas; they were linguists and textual critics, and their work highlighted the ambiguous role played by language and texts in transmitting natural and divine truth. The subject of Christian Hebraism is therefore not peripheral to European history but one that has direct relevance to

⁶¹ On the history of humanism in general see Black, *Humanism and Education*. On the emergence of the ‘Republic of Letters’ see Grafton, *Defenders of the Text*; *idem*, *Bring Out Your Dead*. On the humanist debate about the Hermetic texts see Mulsow (ed.), *Ende des Hermetismus*.

⁶² See al-Maqdisi, *Rise of Humanism in Classical Islam*.

understanding the intellectual changes and challenges characterizing the transition from the ancient to the modern world.⁶³

This is not the place to engage the Christian quest for the ultimate divine language in detail.⁶⁴ Suffice it to say that this search is a common denominator of many scholars of the time, including Guillaume Postel,⁶⁵ Johannes Reuchlin, Athanasius Kircher, John Dee, Francis Mercury van Helmont, and Christian Knorr von Rosenroth. Van Helmont and Knorr collaborated at the court of Sulzbach; it was with the newly established press there that van Helmont published his *Kurtzer Entwurff des eigentlichen Naturalphabets der Heiligen Sprache* (1667), with a preface by Knorr.⁶⁶ Van Helmont argued in this philosophical work that Hebrew was the divine language of creation and that the Hebrew words exactly expressed the essential nature of things, which fits the kabbalistic ontologization of letters that I explained above. Van Helmont was convinced that while time and ignorance had led to the corruption of Hebrew, he had actually rediscovered its original form. In a climate of religious and political tension, van Helmont expected consolation and unity from the study of the primordial language that he had found. He shared this messianic expectation with his friend, Knorr von Rosenroth.

Van Helmont and Knorr were no exception in the seventeenth century. Quite the contrary: beginning with the sixteenth century, we can see a line of thought that conceptualized language as a mirror and source of universal knowledge. The quest for universal languages was part and parcel of an apocalyptic mindset and the experience of religious wars. As Robert E. Stillman notes with regard to Comenius' *Via lucis* (1641):

Out of linguistic divisions come war, religious strife, and cultural chaos; from linguistic renewal are promised not just peace but also the utopian benefits of a Christianopolis. Such ideas are startling, but in a

⁶³ The editors' introduction to Coudert & Shoulson, *Hebraica Veritas?*, 12.

⁶⁴ Coudert (ed.), *Language of Adam*, and Eco, *Search for the Perfect Language*, provide good introductions to the topic.

⁶⁵ Kuntz, "Hebrew and the 'Other Sister' Arabic"; Klein, "Christliche Kabbala und Linguistik orientalischer Sprachen."

⁶⁶ In English the book is usually known simply as the *Alphabet of Nature*; see Coudert, *Impact of the Kabbalah*, 58–99; see also Coudert's and Corse's new translation of the text.

seventeenth-century context they were far from extraordinary. In no other period of Western culture was so much power attributed to words or such great expectations attached to their reform. At the same time, in no other period was so much suspicion voiced about their abuse. The important point here is control. For beneath the veneration of linguistic power and the fear of its abuse, in Comenius, as in Bacon, Hobbes, Wilkins, and the other writers of the English tradition, lies a strong desire to master language, which is also a desire to master history.⁶⁷

Comenius is an important link between mystical-esoteric concepts—Böhme's *Natursprache*—and the universal languages of the later natural philosophers. In Comenius we can see “that linguistic perfection—a renewal of the bonds between language and nature—is the means to Edenic perfection, a salvation from history.”⁶⁸ Thus, Stillman concludes:

A perfect language is the fulfillment of desire: it is the marriage of words to things. When midway through the seventeenth century John Webster envisions the creation of a universal language, he makes the revealing argument that its discovery would serve “to marry the world, that is, fitly and duly to join and connex agents to their patients, masculines to faeminines, superious [sic] to inferiours, Caelestials to terrestrials, that thereby nature may act out her hidden and latent power.”⁶⁹

The tragedy of nominalism has gone full circle. While nominalists had tried to divorce words and things, the quest for the universal language tied them together again. Philologists and philosophers of the seventeenth century ontologized language in such a way that the kabbalistic understanding of the ultimate qualities of letters and words could easily be adopted.

⁶⁷ Stillman, *New Philosophy and Universal Languages*, 30. On universal languages in early modern Europe see also Slaughter, *Universal Languages*.

⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 31.

⁶⁹ *Ibid.*, 33. The reference is to John Webster's *Academiæ examen; or, The Examination of Academies*.

